

Pelt

Caroline woke up in bed after this last drought. Looked down at herself and saw the blankets and whatnot, but felt an odd texture on her back and head. She tried to reach towards it but couldn't without cramping up a bit. Wanted to see what was going on, so yanked the blankets and sheets off. Phone tumbled to the floor. Ugh. Rolled out of the bed and into the bathroom. She was wearing a wolf pelt. Of course. It wasn't uncommon for droughtexit to find her in something odd on waking. This time was a bit of a curveball though. A man, in the corner of the room, spoke up. Leaned out of the bathroom with her head only. He almost laughed. Said, "You're quite the character in the droughts." Responded, "And who might you be?" Said, "I'm your dagumn brother, Caroline." Oh. Didn't recognize hanging head out the bathroom door. Well. Responded, "And what, pray tell, kind of character am I in the droughts, *Jesse*?" Said, "You uh, you go... why do you think you're wearing a wolf pelt?"

Caroline poured honey in the coffee pot's basket, over the coffee grounds. Had no idea if it did anything, but started doing it on special occasions after an episode a while back. Every time she decided to write down or otherwise document what the honey in the basket did to the taste, she'd either forget, get distracted, or stop caring. It didn't matter to her, for her. Jesse made a face and Caroline did her best to ignore it and overwrite the image in her mind with nonsense, stifle the view from taking hold in the long-term history within her. She wondered why it was that so few people seemed to talk these days.

Jesse hadn't had coffee for the duration of the last drought, and this last one had just ended. How he made it to Caroli's apartment, he didn't remember. Of course. But, he thought, he at least got to see how Caroli responded to realizing who he was. That honest moment when someone registers who you are and you see their honest, organic reaction to the intersection between them and yourself. She may not have recognized him, but that could be attributed to the residual drought still lingering in the corners of her eyes. "Droughtfog," he mused. Smiled, inwardly. The coffee was good. Odd, but good. The flavor was intense and he couldn't quite put his finger on how or why, but it was dimly sweet despite being fully black. It was a bit of a relief to finally have a cup after so long. Unlike Caroli, he didn't have the privilege of waking up slowly from a drought. Instead he was an insomniac throughout them and only on droughtexit could be *start* to incorporate microsleeping into his day. Eventually build up through the units of measure toward the usual, uninterrupted and normal sleep that most everyone seemed to have access to. More readily have access, at least. He understood the discomfort of droughtexit growing pains, no doubt. Kind of hard not to feel bad for them, with them screaming bloody murder like that. He knew of a few people who didn't wake up screaming, but there was no discernible pattern to who or who not. And each person's experience was different. Caroli interested him partially because, he'd heard and had now seen, that should could bring relics or whatever the frick back from the droughts. He wondered if these objects were things she actually interacted with in a drought or if they

were inwardly constituted and then externalized into the container of the given object: Were they objects she was actually touching in the droughts, or was she materializing them during or after each drought?

Said, "I have some questions for you, Caroline." Responded, "You and me both buddy brother o' mine. But sure, lay one on me now that we've got coffee and the porch under us." Jesse loved his sister. They spent a few years just killing time on his porch when he was in college and she a 10-15 minute walk away. Drinking, chain smoking, etcetera. Said, "Do you remember the droughts afterward?" Responded, "Only when I'm touching an object I wake up with, that came from one." She gazed through the window at the pelt. She'd taken an ecology class in her own college years and wondered about the pelt, wondered why it was that this particular drought she couldn't form a linear memory from it. She only had fragments and blurred images when she touched the pelt. Unlike when she touched the other relics from other droughts. Those relic-memories were so fluid and seamless. Yet this relic didn't correspond evenly to what it had to say: it shared fragmentation, yes, but the pelt was beautiful and seamless. Flowed more beautifully, more cathartically than any of the memories shared by the previous relics. Said, "Caroli—" Responded, "You know I don't like being compared to a cannoli, Jesse." Said, "Caroline, I don't even understand how we're—how the people like us—are supposed to form a shared language...? None of us are similar to the next and none of us have the same experience or perspective or—" Responded, "Jesse maybe that's the fuckin' point." Didn't think of that. Jesse launched into a reverie of his own which Caroline promptly (and gladly) ignored. She wanted to get lost in the labyrinthinian curves of her own puzzles and mysteries.

His mind rolled in place of his eyes. Jesse didn't want to let on that her comment had irritated him. Sure, us all being different *may* be the point, but what does that make the point then? A technique of his was to meander around an adjacent topic when the topic in question was stumping him. This time, he chose to think about that comment of his about a shared language. Why had he chosen that phrasing, he wondered. And more importantly, why did it feel so true? In the history of the world, many groups of people were torn apart or split or separated by other groups, nations, etcetera. And so the diaspora was born: people without their home and people without their people. Jesse turned his attention to his own situation. The inverse of a diaspora? What does it mean to *start* separated, and what does it look like to search for community on waking up to a new identity. His questions were becoming more terse inside himself. Devolving into statements, declaratives. Imperatives bubbled to the surface of the list and he began moving toward the door to take a closer look at the wolf pelt. What the heckin' hell was going on anymore. He hadn't even bothered trying to have a drawn out or detailed conversation about the droughts with a screamer. Is what he called them. "Apparently," he murmured. "Screamers," he thought. "Does *not* have a nice ring to it." If no one would create a terminology for them, he supposed he would take it on himself to at least start. Caroline clearly wasn't interested. Found the pelt inside and felt Caroli staring at him

as he approached it. He intuited that touching it, or moving it, was out of the question. The frick was he supposed to do then, if those two actions were off the table. He walked over down the hallway a little, found a rod or whatever the heck and started to pretend. He sheathed the rod, then unsheathed. Held the rod vertically up against his nose, as if about to say, *En garde*. Finally settled on fencing the pelt. Nevermind that it was a shower curtain rod, or that the end was a flat rubber plug. Caroli was rolling laughing. She didn't realize that her stick-in-the-mud brother could be this goofy without substances.

Came back outside to the porch and sat next to his sister, wondered if he could ask another question without any hemming and hawing. Said, "What happens when you touch the pelt." He was using the terseness of his own inner monologue in speech now, figured that some terseness would seem more nonchalant or more casual. His curiosity was neither nonchalant nor casual: this new question had a firm grip on his mind at this point and he had no idea what she might say. Responded, "The only sense I can make, the only language I have for it, is not 'ours.' Or rather, it's just a word. 'Komorebi': it refers to the light that filters through and escapes the leaves of trees. The light and shadow created by sun, tree, and light. A synthesis of all those things into something ... else." Said, "That's lovely ... but how does—does touching the pelt feel like looking at shadows from tree leaves?" Jesse hadn't expected anything like this. Hadn't expected anything at the outset, but definitely wasn't counting on Japanese terms for light and shadow. Responded, "This is one of the few moments, where putting something into words isn't hard at all. Komorebi describes it perfectly. I wake up from a drought, wearing or touching something new, and for this wolf pelt? I feel komorebi. I can grip the fur of the pelt in my hand and I feel as though the word itself,—it reminds me of Neruda's poem 'Verbo' and just ... yes, this is easy. This is perhaps the easiest I've ever felt about a drought. It's a sort of contentment. Have you ever wondered that the irregularity between all of us for the droughts is so much so that some of us clump together and *do* carry similar experience of them?" Said, "You think that there must be regularity in the irregularity, somewhere. Maybe." Responded, "Thank you for asking me that, about the pelt. It clicked things into place in my mind." Said, "You're welcome. Feel free to keep sharing. It was interesting what you were saying." Jesse picked up a house plant, one of the ones on the porch, and sat it next to him. Reached into his pocket, distracting Caroline as much as he could, and pulled out an invisible container. Mimed the lid opening and his sister made no effort to hide her whole-body eye roll. He laughed as he blew his mime cigarette drag into the leaves of the house plant. Responded, "You're such a fuckin' kook, Jesse." He laughed with a toothy, mischievous smile. Said, "OK sis, I'm good to go. And so is the plant. Freshened her up with some fresh air, too." Responded, "Bloody hell, Jesse, what the hell was I even talking about. What'd you ask me." Said, "The komorebi of your new wolf pelt." Launched, "Touching it makes me feel strong, I'm realizing. It feels like I'm powerful when I hold it. I was too tired to notice when I woke up in it. Like waking up and finishing your first cup of coffee only to see that the bedside lamp was on all night ... When I touch

that pelt, fragments of the drought come to me but there's also that powerful feeling and the image of that power is almost like a ruler with a staff or a cane or some kind of symbolic implement." Said, "Caroline, I meant to tell you earlier but decided it wasn't the time. You were, well you were known as—the reason you woke up in a wolf pelt is because you were a berserker in this last drought. I can speak to the other droughts, but you were going wild." Responded, "Hm. That must be why the pelt speaks in such strong symbolism. It doesn't feel like the images are wild though. I wonder what that . . . Jesse—you do realize that there's a contradiction between my and your experience now. I don't know that I'm aware of this for or between anyone else." Said, "I want to hear more about this komorebi thing." Responded, "The pelt gives me pieces of light that break through and fall around the trees and the leaves and the branches and the shadows of my life. Each fragment the pelt gives, feels like a piece of a dream." She closed her eyes and felt the pulse of her life and recalled other shards of dreams in her life. Remembered the swampy house their childhood dog lived in with an old witch, remembered the lamplit dock somewhere in the delta that felt as mystical as it was deserted. Dreams bubbled and popped in her mind, like the cauldron their family dog's witch probably had out back. Caroline, up to that point, had already felt the truth of *fleeting* komorebi; now, she was grasping the broader, overarching permanence of its comings and goings. Said, "That's lovely, Caroline." Responded, "None of this new, Jesse." She was holding the pelt. Jesse wasn't entirely sure how she got it or when she had left to go get it, but so it was. Said, "What do you feel now?" Shedding *kisame* tears, "Catharsis."